AAZHI · Six continuity failures

The failed prompts, what came back, why each one broke continuity, and the lesson now in the bible. Ranjith, showreel s13 and s23–s24, November 2026.

#	Shot	What went wrong	Lesson
1	s23-sh02 v1	The bow at night: a different boat, Antony sitting	**L85**: A shot that continues the previous one always starts from that shot's last frame
2	s23-sh05 v3	Retake rewrote everything: the working set fell apart	**L114**: When a take worked, the retake changes only the one thing that was wrong
3	s23-sh06 v5	Strangers at the rail, the burning boat right beside us	**L119**: Every shot is checked against the previous approved frames before it is sent: people, distances and props
4	s23-sh06 v6	New angle seconds later: a different, plastic scene	**L122**: A shot seconds after the last one, from a new angle with only a reference image, came out as a different, plastic scene
5	s13-sh03c v1	High camera: the crew posed for the lens	**L127**: A high camera over a group, with "they look up toward Antony", made every man look up into the lens and smile, like a group photo
6	s13-sh03c v2	Side gangplank, but he walked in from the stern	**L128**: Antony came up a gangplank on the SIDE of the uru, but the take walked him in through the stern and straight down the deck toward the bow

The pattern behind all six

1. The model remembers nothing. Whatever the previous frame showed (the boat, the people, the distance, the light, the gangplank side) must be attached or written down, or it is reinvented.
2. Before every prompt: open every earlier frame of the sequence and fill the Continuity check table (L118, L119).
3. A shot seconds after the last one starts from its last frame, on the same camera (L85, L122).
4. A retake changes only what failed (L114).
5. Write directions and sides as facts: which rail the quay is beyond, where the gangplank is, and where each glance lands, never "into the lens" (L127, L128).

1. The bow at night: a different boat, Antony sitting

L85 Shot **s23-sh02 v1** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s23-sh02-v1.md`



Previous approved shot (s23-sh01): what it had to continue



What came back (v1)

What went wrong

SB029 follows straight on from SB028 (same moment, same bow, same Antony), but the take had no relation to it: a different vessel, a different sky, Antony sitting instead of standing.

Why it failed

the previous approved take's last frame was not attached. Each generation remembers nothing, so without it the model rebuilt the scene from scratch.

Lesson L85: the rule now

1. If a shot carries on from the previous shot (same place, same moment, same people), its start image is the last frame of the previous approved take. It is required, not optional.
2. Keep the previous shot's camera, or move from it within the shot (push-in, pan). Cut to a new angle only when the story needs it, and then still attach the previous last frame as a reference plus the place's plate (L84).
3. Before writing the prompt, ask the creator for that last frame and save it in `scenes/<scene>/<shot>/approved/` (or `scenes/showreel/approved/`). If they don't have it, say the shot is at risk before delivering it.
4. The prompt's FIRST FRAME and the "Start image (0.0s)" reference line both say "the exact first frame: same place, same pose".

What the next version did

v2 started from the last frame of s23-sh01 as its start image and carried the uru plates (L84). Approved.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Late at night, 1998, on the open sea, at the bow of the wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Seen over Antony's
right shoulder: the distant light he noticed is a small wooden fishing boat burning far off on the dark sea, ahead and
to the left. He watches it, worried. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-
sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin
silver chain, barefoot. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only Antony's right shoulder, the back of his head and his right cheek in the foreground, the uru's dark wooden bow
rail and the top of the curved stem post, the dark open sea, the faint horizon, and the small boat burning far away.
Every frame looks like the film itself, with nothing from the making of it. No lettering anywhere.

THE BOW, LOOKING FORWARD-LEFT (0.0s–8.0s)
Seen from just behind Antony's right shoulder at his eye height, looking forward and to the left over the bow. Antony
```

fills the right third of the frame, back three-quarters to the view, his right cheek and the line of his jaw just visible, his hands on the dark wooden bow rail with turned posts; the top of the uru's tall curved wooden stem post rises dark just left of him. Beyond, in the LEFT third of the frame, about half a kilometre away on the open sea: one small wooden fishing boat, low and narrow, burning along its whole length; flames a few metres high, sparks lifting, a column of dark smoke lit orange from below leaning to the right in the breeze, a long flickering orange reflection on the water toward us. The boat stays small and far; no people, no other boats, nothing else of it can be made out.

FIRST FRAME
Over Antony's right shoulder, his hands on the rail, looking forward-left; the small boat already burning far off in the left third of the frame.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS over the shoulder 40°: Antony's shoulder and head soft in the foreground; the burning boat sharp in the distance.

CAMERA
A locked-off, perfectly steady view at eye height, rising and falling very gently with the swell, level horizon.

ACTION
0.0s to 2.0s: A quiet beat, never frozen: Antony leans on the rail watching the fire, breathing in his shoulders, swaying with the roll; the flames flicker and the smoke rolls up.
2.0s to 5.5s: The fire flares: a burst of flame and sparks climbs from the boat and the reflection brightens on the water; Antony straightens, his right hand tightening on the rail, his head tilting as he narrows his eyes, his jaw setting; he shifts his weight forward.
5.5s to 8.0s: A quiet, worried beat: he leans in again, breathing faster, his shoulders tense, swaying with the deck, eyes on the fire; he keeps living the whole time.

PERFORMANCE
Concern: a young sailor realising this is a boat on fire, and people may be on it; worry in the set jaw, the grip and the breathing, all from behind and the edge of his face. Natural and loose, never stiff, never a statue, never theatrical.

PHYSICS
The bow rises and falls on the gentle swell; his shirt collar and hair stir in the night breeze; the far flames flicker and lean with the breeze, sparks rising and fading; the smoke drifts right; the orange reflection breaks and re-forms on the swell; the burning boat rocks slightly on the water.

LIGHTING
Night, natural and dark: faint cool moonlight from the right, a thin rim on Antony's right shoulder, ear and hair; the near deck and rail in near-black shadow; the fire the only warm light, bright and orange far away, lighting its own smoke and the water around it, too far to light the uru or Antony. No glossy or polished look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: the bow cutting through the swell, water hissing along the hull, the stem post creaking, a soft breeze; far off, the faint crackle of the fire carried on the wind.
2.0s–5.5s: his hand gripping the wooden rail; his breath catching once.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala period feature film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the bright distant fire and the deep night shadows in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool, dark, natural moonlit night palette with one small, far orange fire.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Antony seen from behind his right shoulder, back three-quarters, only the edge of his face, never looking at the view; moving naturally the whole shot, never frozen. The burning boat stays small and far, in the left third of the frame, the only fire; no people seen on it and nothing of what happened to it. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

2. Retake rewrote everything: the working set fell apart

L114 Shot **s23-sh05 v3** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s23-sh05-v3.md`



The v2 take that had worked



What came back (v3)

What went wrong

v2 had worked; the only note was that the three crewmen woke and moved in unison. v3 rewrote the whole action (new end positions, Aashaan moving to the doorway, Antony stopping elsewhere, shorter scene text). The take lost what v2 had: the wheel showed very big in the deckhouse windows, nobody was readable at the start, and Antony came out of the deckhouse instead of running in from the bow.

Why it failed

too many changes at once; every rewritten sentence is a new chance for the model to go wrong, and trimming to fit the length cut lines that were holding the set together.

Lesson L114: the rule now

1. For a retake of a take that mostly worked, start from that prompt word for word and change only the sentences the creator's note is about. List the changed sentences in the shot's History.
2. Never trim working lines to make room; trim elsewhere or keep the new detail short.
3. A person not in the start frame keeps the entry the working take used (L100); the deckhouse doorway is Aashaan's only.

What the next version did

v4 went back to the v2 prompt word for word and changed only the lines about the crew waking in unison (L113). Approved.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Deep night, 1998, on the open sea, on the main deck of the big wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Woken by
Antony's shout, the three crewmen wake one after another and make for the right-hand rail, where Antony runs in from
the bow; they end up spread out, staring out to sea. Nobody moves to help. Aashaan comes to the doorway. Nobody
speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s): the last frame of the earlier shot from this same view (s21-sh01), if kept: the same deck,
mats, deckhouse and men.
@urudeckc1platenight (0.0s–8.0s, full): the main deck looking aft exactly as in the reference: the carved wooden
deckhouse with its windows and half-open door glowing from one lantern inside, the wheel seen through the windows,
mats on the clear deck, the dark sea beyond the RIGHT rail, a half moon high on the left. 100% matches the reference.
@raghavan (0.0s–8.0s, full): Raghavan, about 60, thin and wiry, very dark weathered skin, short grey hair, grey
moustache, white cotton vest, red-and-white checked towel round his neck, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@babu (0.0s–8.0s, full): Babu, about 40, heavy-set, thick black moustache, red-and-white checked towel tied round his
head, off-white half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, grey-brown checked lungi. 100% matches the reference.
@sasi (0.0s–8.0s, full): Sasi, about 35, lean, long thick black curly hair to the shoulders, full black beard, stained
off-white half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@aashaan (0.0s–8.0s, full, small, inside the deckhouse): Aashaan, about 60, grey hair combed back, grey moustache,
cream half-sleeve shirt open over a white vest, white towel on his LEFT shoulder, white mundu. 100% matches the
```

reference.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin silver chain. 100% matches the reference.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only the main deck, the mats, the deckhouse with Aashaan inside, the right-hand rail with the dark sea beyond, the sacks, the moon, and exactly five men: Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Antony and Aashaan. Nothing from the making of the film. No lettering anywhere.

THE DECK (0.0s–8.0s)
Seen from the main deck forward of the deckhouse at standing eye height, looking aft, exactly as in the reference. On the mats at the start: Raghavan on his back with the towel over his eyes, Babu on his side facing the right rail, Sasi asleep against the sacks. Inside the deckhouse, framed by the middle windows, Aashaan at the wheel. The right-hand rail runs down the right of the frame; beyond it the black sea.

FIRST FRAME
The three men asleep on their mats, Aashaan at the wheel inside the glowing deckhouse; the deck still.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
WS 63°, natural depth of field: every man and the deckhouse readable.

CAMERA
A locked-off, steady view at standing eye height, rising and falling gently with the swell, level horizon.

ACTION
Each man moves at his own moment and in his own way, never together.
0.0s to 2.0s: At 0.3s Raghavan wakes first, pulls the towel off his eyes and sits straight up, staring toward the bow. At 1.0s Babu pushes up on one elbow, blinking, looking round. Sasi sleeps on until 1.6s, then lifts his head slowly and rubs his face. Inside, Aashaan turns his head at 0.6s.
2.0s to 5.5s: At 2.0s Raghavan is up first and hurries to the right-hand rail nearest the camera, grabs it and leans out. At 2.6s Antony runs in past the right edge of the frame from the bow and stops at the rail two steps further aft, pointing out to sea toward the bow. At 3.0s Babu gets up, straightening the towel on his head as he walks, and stops a step short of the rail, behind Raghavan's shoulder. At 3.5s Aashaan steps into the deckhouse doorway. At 4.0s Sasi gets to his knees, then to his feet, and comes slowly, stopping well back from the rail beside the sacks, behind Antony.
5.5s to 8.0s: A tense beat, everyone in a different place and pose: Raghavan leaning on the rail nearest the camera; Babu standing back behind him, one hand on his head towel; Antony at the rail further aft, arm still raised, looking from the sea to the men; Sasi back by the sacks, arms folded tight; Aashaan in the doorway, a hand on the frame. Nobody climbs or moves to help; each keeps a small movement: Babu shakes his head, Sasi shifts his weight, Raghavan breathes fast.

PERFORMANCE
Fear and hesitation in the crew, each man differently: Raghavan alarmed, Babu unsure, Sasi frightened and hanging back; urgency in Antony. Bodies loose and real, never posed, never frozen.

PHYSICS
The deck rises and falls on the swell; the mats and cloth shift as the men get up; the lantern sways inside the deckhouse and the window glow moves.

LIGHTING
Deep night, natural and dark: warm lantern glow from the deckhouse windows and door; faint moonlight from the half moon high on the left; a faint flickering orange glow from beyond the right rail on the men's faces. No glossy look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: water along the hull, rigging creaking; 0.5s–5.5s mats rustling, footsteps on the planks; 5.5s–8.0s quick breaths; far off, a fire crackling.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the lantern-lit deckhouse and the dark deck in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool dark night with one warm lantern.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Exactly five men: by the end Raghavan and Antony at the RIGHT rail, Babu a step back behind Raghavan, Sasi well back by the sacks, Aashaan in the deckhouse doorway. Never in a row, never side by side, never moving together; different distances and poses. Nobody climbs the rail or jumps. The moon stays high on the left. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

3. Strangers at the rail, the burning boat right beside us

L119 Shot **s23-sh06 v5** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s23-sh06-v5.md`



Previous approved frame (s23-sh05): our crew, the fire a far point



What came back (v5)

What went wrong

the close-up came back with two men who are not our characters (both in Antony-style striped shirts), the burning vallam close and big beside the uru, a lantern on a post that never existed, and different words. Every earlier approved frame (s23-sh01, sh02, sh05) has the fire as a small far light on the horizon and our own crew at the rail. Each wrong generation costs credits.

Why it failed

1. The prompt named Raghavan and Babu many times (eyeline, performance, locks, "camera beside Raghavan's head") without attaching them; the model put two men in and built them from the only sheet attached, `@antony20`.
2. The prompt moved the fire to "about 150 metres" and attached `@burningvallam`, a close-up picture, so the boat was drawn close. No approved shot ever brought it near.
3. Nothing compared the prompt with the previous approved frames before it was sent.

Lesson L119: the rule now

1. Before every prompt, open the previous approved frames (last frame of the shot before, plus the earlier shots of the same moment) and fill a Continuity check table in the shot file: element · previous frames · this shot. Every person, the key prop's distance and size, light sides and props in hands. The prompt's CONTINUITY block (L118) is written from that table.
2. Anyone who could appear in the frame (the people the speaker talks to, people standing near him) is attached with their own sheet and placed explicitly (seen from behind, soft, where in the frame). Never name a person in the prompt without attaching them or saying plainly they are out of frame.
3. Distances do not change between shots unless a shot shows them changing. Write the distance in metres and the size in the frame ("a tiny orange point on the horizon") and check it in a 3D blocking camera view at real distances (`tools/blocking3d.py`, camera eye at the shot's position).
4. A close-up picture of a prop that must look far away is attached only with the size lock in its reference line, the location line and POSITIVE LOCKS.
5. Lock the head count: "exactly N people in frame: ...; no one else, no copies".

What the next version did

Every person who could appear was attached; the fire went back to about 500 m; the distance sheet (continuity/night-rescue-distances.md) and the Continuity check table started here.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Deep night, 1998, on the open sea, at the left-hand rail of the big wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot. Antony, his
back to the rail, the burning vallam and a man in the water behind him, orders Raghavan and Babu in Malayalam to bring
```

a rope. He is alone in the frame.
SPOKEN LANGUAGE: Malayalam. Every spoken word in this video is Malayalam, the exact Malayalam text given in quotes in AUDIO. No English words are spoken.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the last frame of s23-sh05.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin silver chain. Native Kollam-coast Malayalam speaker; warm, slightly hoarse young voice. 100% matches the reference.
@burningvallam (0.0s–8.0s, background only): the same burning boat, about 150 metres off behind Antony, small in the frame; nobody on board. 100% matches the reference.
@selvan (0.0s–8.0s, background only, small): only his head and one raised arm in a soaked light-blue tiger-stripe sleeve, in the water beside the burning boat; face not readable. 100% matches the reference.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shot, the reference image)
Same night, seconds later. Antony at the left-hand rail nearest the bow, same clothes and chain, his right arm just lowered from pointing out to sea; Raghavan just aft of him; Babu and Sasi further aft; Aashaan at the wheel inside. The burning vallam ahead-left of the boat, ~150 m off, the man in the water beside it. Lantern light from the deckhouse aft; night as dark as before.

THE RAIL (0.0s–8.0s)
From the deck a little aft of Antony and inboard, at his eye height, looking at him with the left-hand rail and the sea behind him. Only Antony is in frame. Behind him, over the dark rail with turned posts: the black sea and, right of frame centre, the burning vallam; beside its hull the small head and raised arm of a man in the water, lit orange. No lettering.
EYELINE: Raghavan and Babu stand just off the left edge of the frame; the camera is right beside Raghavan's head. Antony's head is turned a little toward them, his eyes on theirs about 20 degrees left of the lens: not right, not down, never into the lens.

FIRST FRAME
Antony at the rail, his right arm coming down from pointing, already looking at Raghavan and Babu just left of the lens; the fire behind him.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MCU 30° easing to a tight MCU by 6.0s: Antony sharp; the burning boat and the man in the water behind him compressed, readable, a little softer.

CAMERA
Eye level, starting 2.0 m from his face; the camera travels straight toward him at about 0.25 km/h, easing in over the first second, keeping on through the line, and settles about 1.5 m away at 6.0s, then holds. Straight in, no arc, no sideways drift; a smooth weighted glide rising and falling gently with the swell. Focus on his eyes and mouth.

ACTION
0.0s to 3.0s: Antony lowers his right arm, eyes on Raghavan and Babu, breathing fast, his jaw setting; a short breath in.
3.0s to 4.2s: He gives his order in Malayalam, firm and loud enough over the sea, head steady, eyes on them.
4.2s to 8.0s: Silence. He says nothing more, mouth closed; nobody moves; he glances back over his shoulder at the man in the water, then grips the rail top with both hands, ready, breathing fast.

DIALOGUE RULES
Dialogue rules: whenever a character speaks, frame them in a medium close-up with their face filling at least a third of the frame height. The speaking face is turned toward the camera, no more than 30 degrees from the lens, upright and not lying sideways. Only one person speaks in the shot; everyone else keeps their mouth closed. The speaker's head stays steady during the line; head turns and gestures happen only in pauses between lines. The mouth is always fully visible, with nothing in front of the face, and the face is lit with soft, even frontal light. Natural, clearly articulated mouth movements matching the dialogue.
While a line is spoken, the speaker is the only person in the frame.

PERFORMANCE
Resolve: he has decided, fear pushed down. Real, conversational speech: natural breaths, not over-pronounced, not acted. Antony always looking at Raghavan and Babu while he speaks.

LIGHTING
Deep night: soft warm lantern light from aft evenly on his face; faint moonlight on his hair; the far fire lights its smoke and water. No glossy look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build.
Spoken language: Malayalam only, not English and not a translation. Antony says the exact Malayalam words written in quotes below, in everyday Kollam coastal Malayalam pronunciation, and nothing else. Lip-sync exact; every word is spoken on camera by Antony, who is alone in frame. The line is spoken once, exactly as written.

3.0s to 4.2s: Antony, Kollam coast accent, firm and quick, stress on "കയറും", falling pitch. About 1.2 seconds. "കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!"

Sound effects: water along the hull; the far fire. From 4.2s to 8.0s only these and his breathing: nobody speaks. No other voices.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the lantern light on his face and the far fire on the black sea in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool dark night, one far orange fire.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Antony alone in frame, MCU, back to the left-hand rail, eyes on Raghavan and Babu just left of the lens while he speaks, never into it. The camera only pushes straight in. Behind him, right of frame centre, the burning vallam about 150 metres off with the small man struggling beside it the whole shot. Silent for the last 3.8 seconds. Every word is Malayalam. Runs the full 8 seconds.

When @antony20 says "കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!" let it be firm and decided, a young man telling older men what to do, right now

4. New angle seconds later: a different, plastic scene

L122 Shot **s23-sh06 v6** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s23-sh06-v6.md`



Previous approved frame (s23-sh05): dark, real, frightened



What came back (v6)

What went wrong

after the dark, real s23-sh05 frame (the four frightened men at the rail, the carved deckhouse, one lantern), the next shot showed a plain low wall and empty sea, bright even studio light, plastic skin, Antony standing stiff and half smiling, a whole burning boat in view, and it ran 5 s instead of 8. It did not look like the same film.

Why it failed

1. A new camera angle with the previous frame only as a reference image: the model kept the faces but rebuilt the set, light and mood.
2. Calm words: "Resolve: he has decided", "firm", plus the dialogue block's "soft, even frontal light" made a calm, evenly lit face. Nothing said fear.
3. The platform duration was left at 5 s.

Lesson L122: the rule now

1. A shot that happens seconds after the last one uses the last frame as the START image on the SAME camera (push in, pan or tilt from there); a new angle only when the story needs it, and then the reverse is planned with its own start frame (L109).
2. When the creator wants it for continuity, the listeners may stay in frame while one person speaks (the start frame shows them); lock their mouths closed and keep the speaker's face clear.
3. Write the feeling in every beat and in PERFORMANCE and LOCKS ("fear in every face, nobody smiles"), never only as one abstract word.
4. Light: "exactly the start image's light; no extra light, no bright faces, no plastic skin"; after the dialogue block add that the frontal light is only the practical source (the lantern).
5. Set the platform duration (8 s) every time (L71).

What the next version did

v8 starts from the s23-sh05 last frame on the same camera and pushes in; fear is written into every beat, the light is locked to the start image, and the duration is set to 8 s.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Deep night, 1998, on the open sea, at the left-hand rail of the big wooden cargo uru. One continuous shot, seconds
after the reference image. Antony, back to the rail, tells Raghavan and Babu (backs to the camera) in Malayalam to
bring a rope. Only Antony speaks.
SPOKEN LANGUAGE: Malayalam. Every spoken word in this video is Malayalam, the exact Malayalam text given in quotes in
AUDIO. No English words are spoken.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
```

Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the last frame of s23-sh05: the same men, rail and night.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, sun-browned, short black hair; exactly the reference clothes: short-sleeve lavender-grey and white striped shirt and grey-green checked mundu, never a plain white shirt or trousers; thin silver chain. Native Kollam-coast Malayalam speaker; warm, slightly hoarse young voice. 100% matches the reference.
@raghavan (0.0s–8.0s, back and right shoulder only, soft foreground): Raghavan, about 60, short grey hair, white cotton vest, red-and-white checked towel round his neck; back to the camera. 100% matches the reference.
@babu (0.0s–8.0s, back of head and shoulder only, soft, far left): Babu, heavy-set, red-and-white checked towel tied round his head, off-white shirt; back to the camera. 100% matches the reference.
@burningvallam (0.0s–8.0s, background only, tiny): the same burning boat, only a tiny orange point on the far horizon, about half a kilometre away. 100% matches the reference.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shots, the reference image)
Same night, seconds later. Antony at the left rail nearest the bow, same clothes and chain, empty hands, right arm just lowered from pointing; Raghavan just aft of him, Babu beside Raghavan; Sasi and Aashaan out of frame. The fire where every earlier shot had it: a small far light on the horizon ahead-left of the boat, never closer. Lantern light from the deckhouse aft.

THE RAIL (0.0s–8.0s)
From the deck a little aft of Antony, at eye height, over Raghavan's right shoulder. Left third, close and soft: the back of Raghavan's grey head, checked towel and right shoulder; at the far left edge, softer, the back of Babu's head with the checked head towel. Centre-right, sharp: Antony chest up, his back to the dark wooden rail with turned posts. Behind him the black sea to a faint horizon; on it, right of centre, the tiny orange point of the burning vallam. No lantern, no post, no other boat. No lettering.
EYELINE: Antony looks at Raghavan's face, just left of the lens, about 20 degrees: not right, not down, never into the lens.

FIRST FRAME
Raghavan's and Babu's backs soft at the left, Antony sharp at centre-right, eyes on Raghavan; the tiny far fire on the horizon.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS 34° over the shoulder easing to MCU by 6.0s: Antony sharp; the two men soft in front; the horizon a little soft.

CAMERA
Eye level, starting 2.0 m from Antony; travels straight toward him at about 0.25 km/h past Raghavan's shoulder, easing in, settling 1.5 m away at 6.0s, then holds. No arc, no drift; a smooth glide rising and falling with the swell. Focus on Antony's eyes and mouth.

ACTION
0.0s to 3.0s: Antony lowers his right arm, eyes on Raghavan, breathing fast; Raghavan's shoulder rises with his breath; Babu shifts his weight.
3.0s to 4.2s: Antony gives his order in Malayalam, firm, head steady, eyes on Raghavan. Raghavan and Babu stay silent, faces away from the camera.
4.2s to 8.0s: Silence. Nobody moves; Raghavan shakes his head slightly; Antony glances back at the far fire, then grips the rail with both hands, ready.

DIALOGUE RULES
Dialogue rules: whenever a character speaks, frame them in a medium close-up with their face filling at least a third of the frame height. The speaking face is turned toward the camera, no more than 30 degrees from the lens, upright and not lying sideways. Only one person speaks in the shot; everyone else keeps their mouth closed. The speaker's head stays steady during the line; head turns and gestures happen only in pauses between lines. The mouth is always fully visible, with nothing in front of the face, and the face is lit with soft, even frontal light. Natural, clearly articulated mouth movements matching the dialogue.
Only Antony's face is seen; Raghavan and Babu are seen from behind and never speak.

PERFORMANCE
Resolve: he has decided. Real, conversational speech, not acted. Antony always looking at Raghavan; the two men uneasy, never frozen.

LIGHTING
Deep night: soft warm lantern light from aft, off frame left, evenly on Antony's face, rimming Raghavan's hair; the far fire lights nothing near. No glossy look.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build.
Spoken language: Malayalam only, not English and not a translation. Antony says the exact Malayalam words written in quotes below, in everyday Kollam coastal Malayalam pronunciation, and nothing else. Lip-sync exact; every word is spoken on camera by Antony. The line is spoken once, exactly as written.

3.0s to 4.2s: Antony, Kollam coast accent, firm and quick, stress on "കയറും", falling pitch. About 1.2 seconds.
"കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!"

Sound effects: water along the hull, rigging creaking. From 4.2s only these and breathing; no other voices.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the lantern light on his face and the dark sea in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Cool dark night, warm lantern light.

POSITIVE LOCKS
Exactly three men in frame: Antony (striped shirt) facing us, Raghavan (grey hair, checked towel round his neck) and Babu (checked head towel) from behind; no one else, no copies of Antony. Only Antony speaks; only his face is seen. The burning vallam stays a tiny far point on the horizon right of centre, never near. All Malayalam. Runs the full 8 seconds.

When @antony20 says "കയറും കൊണ്ടുവാ!" let it be firm and decided, a young man telling older men what to do, right now

5. High camera: the crew posed for the lens

L127 Shot **s13-sh03c v1** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s13-sh03c-v1.md`



Previous approved frame (s13-sh02): the gangplank and the bag



What came back (v1)

What went wrong

the high shot from the rigging came back with Aashaan, Babu, Sasi and Antony standing still, faces up to the camera, smiling, as if posing for a photo. Antony had no bag. The gangplank was a different plank from the one in s13-sh02.

Why it failed

1. The camera was high above them and the prompt said "they look up toward Antony" and "a big grin". "Look up" plus a camera above them = look at the camera.
2. A greeting for every man ("raises a hand", "waves", "grins") turned the work into a welcome line-up.
3. @antonybag was left out because the @antony20 sheet was thought to carry the bag; it does not.
4. The reference image (s13-sh04) did not show the gangplank, so the model invented one.

Lesson L127: the rule now

1. Reveal a group the way a person sees it: follow behind the character who arrives, at his eye height, and let the group open up in front of him. Avoid high or overhead cameras for reaction beats.
2. Each person keeps working. At most one or two people glance at the newcomer, and only briefly. Write where each glance lands on the deck ("at Antony's face, left of the lens") and add the lock "nobody looks at the camera, nobody poses, nobody stops working to smile".
3. Whenever Antony is seen full length or from behind, attach @antonybag (its card says so) and write the bag on his LEFT shoulder in POSITIVE LOCKS.
4. A shot that shows the gangplank or another part of a set seen before uses the frame that shows it (approved/s13-sh02-frame.jpg for the gangplank) as its reference image.

What the next version did

v2 follows behind Antony at eye height; the crew keep working and at most two glance at him; @antonybag is attached; the s13-sh02 frame is the reference image. The posing problem was fixed.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Mid-morning, 1998, aboard the big wooden cargo uru moored at the quay in Cochin harbour. One continuous high shot
looking down on the main deck: the crew at work, Aashaan by the lashed sacks, and Antony, just aboard by the
deckhouse, as the men look up from their work at his greeting. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the s13-sh04 frame of Aashaan at the sacks by the mast: the same deck, mast, sacks,
deckhouse and morning light.
@aashaan (0.0s–8.0s, full): Aashaan, about 60, grey hair combed back, grey moustache, cream half-sleeve shirt over a
white vest, white towel on his LEFT shoulder, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, short black hair, lavender-grey striped shirt, grey-green checked mundu, beige
cloth bag on his LEFT shoulder. 100% matches the reference.
@raghavan (0.0s–8.0s, full): Raghavan, about 60, thin, grey hair and moustache, white vest, red-and-white checked
```

towel round his neck, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@babu (0.0s–8.0s, full): Babu, heavy-set, moustache, red-and-white checked towel tied round his head, off-white shirt over a vest, grey-brown checked lungi. 100% matches the reference.
@sasi (0.0s–8.0s, full): Sasi, long black curly hair, full beard, off-white shirt over a vest, white mundu. 100% matches the reference.
@suresh (0.0s–8.0s, full): Suresh, curly hair, moustache, cream shirt with rolled sleeves, green small-check mundu, a red thread on his right wrist. 100% matches the reference.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shots)
Seconds after Antony called out to Aashaan. Antony by the deckhouse at the quay-side rail, where he stepped off the gangplank. Aashaan by the lashed burlap sacks next to the mast, about four metres forward of him. The crew at work on the main deck. Balan is not aboard yet. Hazy mid-morning sun from the left.

WHAT IS IN FRAME
Only the main deck of the uru from above: the deckhouse roof edge and railings at the top of the frame, the mast rising toward the camera, the lashed sacks, coils of coir rope, the quay-side rail with the stone quay and gangplank beyond it at the right, and exactly six men: Aashaan, Antony, Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Suresh. No lettering.

THE DECK FROM ABOVE (0.0s–8.0s)
High above the deck, about six metres up in the rigging beside the mast, looking down and aft. Placed across the deck at different distances, never in a row: Aashaan by the sacks just below the mast, centre; Antony by the deckhouse at the right, at the quay-side rail, the gangplank behind him; Raghavan coiling a rope on the planks at the left; Babu carrying a sack across the deck in the middle; Sasi kneeling, tightening a lashing near the left rail; Suresh at the quay-side rail forward, handling the mooring rope.

FIRST FRAME
The deck from above, every man at his work, Antony just aboard by the deckhouse at the right, looking toward Aashaan.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
High-angle WS 63°, deep focus: every man and the deck sharp.

CAMERA
High in the rigging, locked-off, looking down; a slow, gentle tilt of a few degrees toward Antony over the shot. No travel.

ACTION
0.0s to 2.0s: Each man at his own work: Raghavan coils rope, Babu carries a sack, Sasi pulls a lashing tight, Suresh loops the mooring rope; Aashaan straightens up from the sacks at the greeting.
2.0s to 5.0s: One after another they look up toward Antony: Aashaan first, raising a hand; Babu sets the sack down at 2.5s and grins; Sasi looks up at 3.0s from his knees; Raghavan glances over at 3.5s and nods; Suresh turns at 4.0s and calls nothing, just waves.
5.0s to 8.0s: Aashaan beckons Antony over with a jerk of his head; Antony walks forward along the deck toward him; the others go back to their work, each at his own pace.

EXPRESSIONS (every face, beat by beat)
Aashaan: pleased, a small satisfied smile under the grey moustache, eyes crinkling; then businesslike again.
Antony: bright, eager, smiling as he walks forward.
Raghavan: a dry, approving look and a slow nod, no big smile.
Babu: a big easy grin, laughing eyes.
Sasi: a quick friendly smile through the beard, then back to the knot, concentrating.
Suresh: a light, cheerful grin, eyebrows up.

PERFORMANCE
Light-hearted morning work; a welcome without fuss. Every man moving at his own time, never in unison; real working bodies.

LIGHTING
Hazy mid-morning sun from the left, warm and soft, long soft shadows across the planks; the quay bright in the haze.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: harbour ambience, gulls, water against the hull, rope creaking, a sack thudding onto the planks at 2.5s, footsteps on wood.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range that holds the hazy bright quay and the shaded deck in one frame; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Warm hazy morning palette.

POSITIVE LOCKS

Exactly six men on deck, one of each: Aashaan, Antony, Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Suresh; no Balan, no copies, no extra people. Never in a row. The quay and gangplank at the right. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

6. Side gangplank, but he walked in from the stern

L128 Shot **s13-sh03c v2** · failed take · prompt from `scenes/showreel/retired/s13-sh03c-v2.md`



Previous approved frame (s13-sh02): side gangplank, bow toward the camera



What came back (v2)

What went wrong

the gangplank became a short ladder into the stern end; Antony walked straight along the centreline toward the bow, as if he had come from behind the boat. There was open water on both sides and no quay, as if the uru were at sea. The bag hung at his right hip on a strap across his body.

Why it failed

the prompt said "steps onto the deck ... looking forward along the main deck toward the bow" and never said that he arrives over the SIDE rail, which way the bow points from the quay, or that he has to turn. Given the shortest version, the model lined the gangplank up with the deck.

Lesson L128: the rule now

1. Whenever someone boards or leaves by a gangplank, write the side: "over the side rail, the quay behind him, the far rail and the water ahead of him".
2. Write the turn as a separate beat: "he turns to his LEFT to face the bow". The camera turns with him (it pans or arcs). Never let the camera look along the deck from the gangplank.
3. For any moored shot, write which rail the quay is beyond: when the deck view faces the bow, the quay is beyond the LEFT rail, with the gangplank's top at that rail.
4. The bag strap goes over his LEFT shoulder only and the bag hangs at his LEFT hip; never across the body.

What the next version did

v3 has him come over the SIDE rail, facing across the deck, then turn left to the bow; the quay is locked beyond the left rail; the bag strap is on his left shoulder only.

The failed prompt, exactly as sent

```
SCENE
Mid-morning, 1998, the stone quay of the old cargo harbour at Cochin, Kerala, and the deck of Antony's big wooden
cargo uru moored beside it. One continuous follow shot close behind Antony: he walks up the gangplank, steps onto the
deck beside the deckhouse, and the deck opens up in front of him with the crew busy at their work, getting the uru
ready to sail. Nobody speaks.

ACTIVE REFERENCES
Reference image (0.0s–8.0s): the s13-sh02 frame: the same quay, uru, carved deckhouse, the same gangplank of cleated
planks with a rope rail up to the deck beside the deckhouse, the same light, Antony from behind.
@antony20 (0.0s–8.0s, full): Antony, 24, lean, short black hair, lavender-grey striped shirt, grey-green checked
mundu, barefoot, seen from behind.
@antonybag (0.0s–8.0s, full): his faded beige canvas bag: strap over his LEFT shoulder, bag at his LEFT hip.
@aashaan (5.0s–8.0s, full): Aashaan, about 60, grey moustache, cream shirt, white towel on his LEFT shoulder, white
mundu.
@raghavan (5.0s–8.0s, full): Raghavan, thin, about 60, white vest, checked towel round his neck.
@babu (5.0s–8.0s, full): Babu, heavy-set, checked towel tied round his head, checked lungi.
@sasi (5.0s–8.0s, full): Sasi, long curly hair, full beard, off-white shirt.
```

@suresh (5.0s–8.0s, full): Suresh, curly hair, cream shirt, green check mundu.

CONTINUITY (carried over from the previous shots)
Straight on from s13-sh02: Antony at the foot of the gangplank from behind, the uru and water at the LEFT, the quay at the RIGHT, bag on his LEFT shoulder, barefoot, hazy warm sun. Balan has not arrived yet.

THE DECK (5.0s–8.0s)
From the top of the gangplank beside the deckhouse, looking forward along the main deck toward the bow: the thick wooden mast about four metres ahead, a stack of burlap sacks lashed with coir rope beside it, coils of rope on the planks, the blue-grey rails on both sides, The strip of deck between Antony and the mast is clear. Everyone is at the mast or forward of it, each at a different distance, never in a row: Aashaan at the sacks beside the mast, pulling the lashing tight; Raghavan sitting forward at the left, coiling rope; Sasi kneeling at the far rail, tying a lashing; Babu carrying a sack forward, away from the camera; Suresh at the forward hatch at the right, stacking a crate. No lettering.

FIRST FRAME
Exactly the reference: Antony from behind at the foot of the gangplank.

FORMAT MODE
One continuous shot; the camera does not cut on its own. The video runs the full 8 seconds.

OPTICS
MS 47° from behind Antony at shoulder height, natural depth of field; when the deck opens up, deep focus so the five men read clearly.

CAMERA
A smooth follow close behind Antony, two metres back, at his shoulder height: it follows him up the gangplank at his walking pace, rising with him, stops at the top of the gangplank as he steps onto the deck, then holds still over his right shoulder, looking forward along the deck. Level horizon, no shake.

ACTION
0.0s to 1.0s: Antony stands at the foot of the gangplank, a hand on the rope rail, the bag at his left hip.
1.0s to 4.5s: He walks up the gangplank with easy, practised steps, barefoot on the wooden cleats; the deckhouse grows larger at the left.
4.5s to 5.5s: He steps over the low rail onto the deck beside the deckhouse and stops, settling the bag strap on his left shoulder.
5.5s to 8.0s: The deck opens up in front of him, every man busy at his own work and his own pace. At 6.5s Aashaan, pulling the lashing tight, glances up at Antony's face for a moment and gives a small nod, then goes back to the rope. At 7.0s Babu, passing with the sack, throws Antony a quick look and walks on. Raghavan, Sasi and Suresh do not look up. Antony stands looking forward at Aashaan, his back to the camera.

EXPRESSIONS (every face, beat by beat)
Antony: seen from behind; shoulders loose and easy, his head lifting as the deck opens up, at home.
Aashaan: busy, brows drawn over the knot; at 6.5s a brief look up, a faint pleased softening of the eyes under the grey moustache; then back to work.
Babu: puffing a little under the sack, a quick friendly flick of the eyes at Antony, mouth closed, then eyes ahead.
Raghavan: absorbed in the rope, lips pressed, an old man's patient frown.
Sasi: concentrating on the knot, jaw set, face half hidden by his curly hair.
Suresh: busy and a little hurried, eyes on the crate.

PERFORMANCE
An ordinary working morning before sailing, weight in every sack and rope. A welcome without fuss: nobody stops working, nobody gathers, nobody poses.

LIGHTING
Exactly the reference's hazy warm morning sun; soft shadows on the planks.

AUDIO
Sound effects only — natural on-location sound, the soundtrack carries no music. No music at all: no score, no background music, no song, no humming, and no cinematic sound design: no riser, no whoosh, no swell, no rumble, no transition sound. Ambient at a steady level that does not build. No spoken words and no voices.
0.0s–8.0s: harbour ambience, gulls, water slapping between the hull and the quay; 1.0s–4.5s bare feet on the wooden cleats and the plank creaking; 4.5s a soft thump onto the deck; 5.5s–8.0s rope creaking, a sack thudding down, a crate set on wood.

STYLE
Photoreal 1998 Kerala film. Shot on a Sony Venice 2 full-frame digital cinema camera: very wide dynamic range; clean, low-noise shadows; soft, gradual highlight roll-off; accurate, natural colour with rich, true skin tones; gentle filmic contrast; fine, organic texture; no over-sharpening, no glossy or video look. Warm hazy morning palette.

POSITIVE LOCKS
One gangplank, exactly as in the reference. Antony seen from behind the whole shot, the bag strap on his LEFT shoulder, the bag at his left hip, barefoot. Exactly six men in the shot, one of each: Antony, Aashaan, Raghavan, Babu, Sasi, Suresh; no Balan, no copies, no extra people. Everyone keeps working; nobody looks at the camera, nobody poses, nobody waves. The deck between Antony and the mast stays clear. Nobody speaks. Runs the full 8 seconds.

```
Let it feel easy and warm: a young sailor coming aboard to a busy deck where he belongs
```